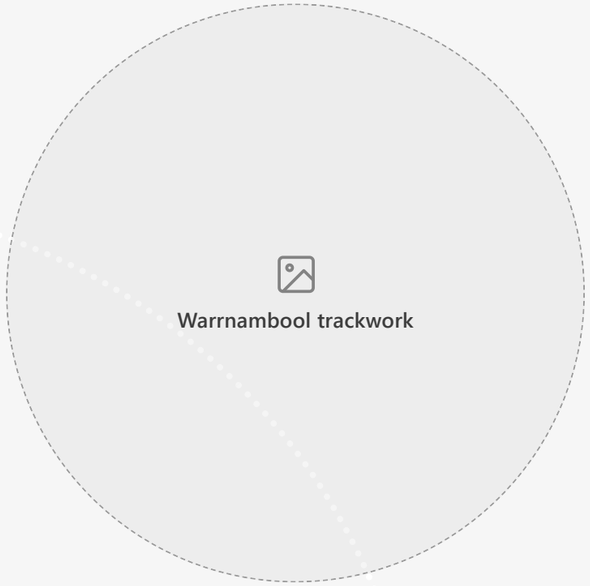
Workforce Development



Warrnambool trackwork

2026 Annual Report – Workforce Development

Stable Start™

Stable Start™, RV's entry-level education program for people seeking a career in the VTRI, continued to provide an important introduction to stable employment and industry training opportunities.

In FY26, 45 participants completed the program, which provides practical experience in horse handling, welfare and workplace safety. Delivered in partnership with the Racing Education Centre, Stable Start™ remains an accessible pathway for individuals looking to commence a career in racing, while also supporting existing stable employees to formalise their qualifications and progress to further training opportunities.

In addition to Stable Start, 104 enrolments were recorded across Certificate III Trackwork Rider qualifications, riding skill sets and mandatory stablehand units during FY26. These training opportunities help develop a skilled workforce while ensuring participants have access to clear pathways for career progression within the industry.

Trackwork Rider Program

RV's Trackwork Rider Program continued to offer aspiring riders structured, practical training within a racetrack environment.

Delivered at Cranbourne and Pakenham, the program provided 16 participants with access to specialist coaching and skill development, supporting the safe acquisition of trackwork riding competencies. The initiative remains a key component of RV's participant development pathway, helping riders build the experience required to pursue long-term careers in racing stables and related industry roles.

Rider Development Squad

The Rider Development Squad (RDS) continued to play a vital role in developing the next generation of trackwork riders and potential apprentice jockeys, with 77 riders participating in the program during FY26.

Educational sessions covered nutrition, sports psychology, goal setting, form analysis, race replay reviews, race tactics and communication, while mechanical horse training and strength and conditioning programs provided opportunities to further enhance riding skills and personal wellbeing.

Current and former jockeys including Jaylah Kennedy, Steven King, Tiani Chapman and Jett Stanley also contributed to the program, assisting with mechanical horse sessions and sharing valuable industry knowledge and experience with participants.

School Tours

RV continued to engage secondary school students through its school tour program, providing structured, behind-the-scenes experiences that showcase the breadth of career opportunities available within the thoroughbred racing industry.

Targeted primarily at students undertaking equine studies programs, the tours were conducted across racecourses and training centres throughout Victoria and highlighted the diverse range of industry roles available beyond riding, including veterinary services, stewarding, media, administration and stable operations. The program also plays an important role in challenging perceptions of the industry and educating students on the high standards of equine welfare that underpin Victorian racing.

During FY26, 160 students participated in tours across metropolitan and regional Victoria, including students from Box Hill Institute, Box Hill Institute Bellarine, Hillcrest College, GOTAFE and local learning and employment networks. With participants typically approaching working age, the initiative continues to serve as an important introduction to potential careers within racing and a pathway into RV's workforce development programs.

Schools-Based Stablehand Training

RV's partnership with education providers continued to create pathways for young people to gain the skills and qualifications required to enter the racing industry.

During FY26, 80 students completed stablehand training with 60 Box Hill Institute students undertaking a program at Pakenham and a further 20 Box Hill Institute Bellarine students completing training at Geelong.

The training incorporated practical horse handling and workplace-based learning experiences, helping students develop the knowledge, confidence and capabilities required for future employment within the VTRI.

Pony Club Victoria Ride to Time Partnership

RV's partnership with Pony Club Victoria (PCV) continued to strengthen grassroots engagement with young riders across the state through the Ride to Time program.



Mr Brightside strapper

Throughout FY26, RV visited 15 Pony Club and attended every zone qualifying event held across PCV's ten zones, with Workforce Development Program Coach and professional jockey Tayla Childs playing a key role in the program's delivery. Designed to develop pace awareness, control, judgement and riding safety, Ride to Time provides participants with practical riding experiences while introducing them and their families to the many career opportunities available within the racing industry.

The 2025 Ride to Time State Championships were held at The Valley on Moir Stakes night with 20 finalists from across Victoria qualifying through regional events to compete in the Maiden and Open divisions. Riders were challenged to complete a 1000-metre course as close as possible to a predetermined benchmark time, demonstrating horsemanship, rhythm and pace judgement.

The championships were followed by RV's first ever Pony Club Rider Development Day, where 20 riders participated in mechanical horse coaching, strength and conditioning sessions delivered by the Victorian Institute of Sport, and educational workshops focused on the role of Stewards, participant protection and wellbeing, and equine welfare. Eight parents and guardians also attended the day, which was held in RV's new state-of-the-art Rider Development Centre at RV headquarters in Flemington.

With more than 30 Ride to Time sessions delivered annually across Victoria, the program continues to provide a strong connection between the equestrian and racing communities while supporting RV's broader workforce development objectives.

Apprentice Jockey Training Program

The Apprentice Jockey Training Program (AJTP) remained the cornerstone of RV's jockey development pathway during FY26, providing aspiring riders with the education, mentoring and practical support required to build successful riding careers.

As at 30 June 2026, 38 apprentice jockeys were enrolled in the four-year program, and nine riders had

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completed the formal training component of the program and continued to ride as claiming apprentices while transitioning towards full senior rider status. ¶ Victoria also rejoined the National Apprentice Racing Series (NARS) in FY26, which was held across the six participating jurisdictions. A sextet of Victorian apprentice jockeys